

EARLY METAL WEAPONS

The first organized armies, those of the Sumerians, are recorded in around 3000 BCE. While heavy war wagons were used, the Sumerians fought largely on foot and carried spears and shields. The development of the spoked wheel enabled much lighter, faster vehicles to be built – open chariots, from which archers could shower enemies with arrows. Thus, chariot warfare came to dominate conflict in the Near East in the second millennium BCE. But as advances in horse breeding produced more robust animals, mounted archers – even faster and more manoeuvrable than chariots – became more valuable to armies in the region, together with infantry foot soldiers equipped with spears, swords, and daggers.



Cheekguards to protect face

Hair-effect decoration

▲ HELMET OF MESKALAMDUG

Date c.2500 BCE

Origin Sumeria

Length 22cm (8½in)

Material Gold, silver

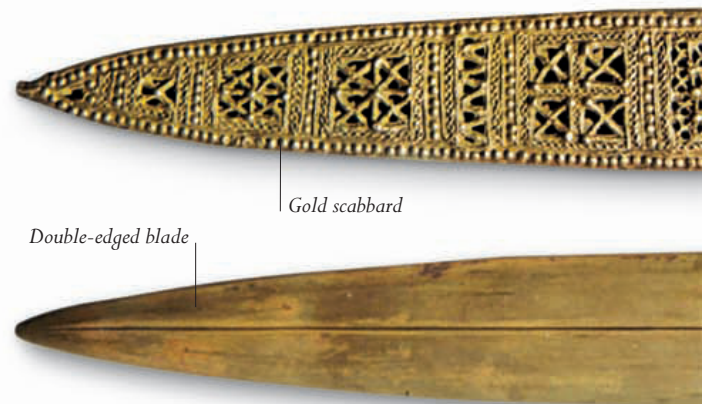
This ceremonial, gold-and-silver alloy helmet was found in the tomb of Meskalamdug at Ur in Sumeria. It is known as a wig helmet, because of the intricately carved imitation of hair on the crown.



Crescent-shaped blade



Central groove to stop scale slipping



Gold scabbard

Double-edged blade

▲ SUMERIAN DAGGER

Date c.2500 BCE

Origin Sumeria

Length 20–30cm (8–12in)

This ornate ceremonial dagger was excavated from the tomb of Queen Pu-Abi at Ur. Its blade and scabbard are crafted in gold, while the hilt is made from lapis lazuli trimmed in gold.



Scabbard with relief decoration of animals and mounted men

▲ PHOENICIAN DAGGER

Date 18th century BCE

Origin Phoenicia

Length 39.3cm (15½in)

The Phoenicians occupied trading cities of the Levantine coast and were known more as merchants than warriors. This magnificent gold and ivory dagger and scabbard signified the bearer's wealth and were not intended for military use.



▲ ASSYRIAN SCALE ARMOUR

Date 1800–620 BCE

Origin Assyria

Length 5cm (2in)

Assyrian soldiers wore a *sariam*, a long coat made of lamellar armour. Bronze scales, such as these, were laced together through holes punched in the side. A complete set of armour consisted of up to 1,000 scales, weighing 15–25kg (33–55lb).

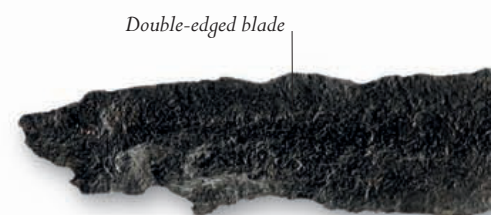
◀ PERSIAN BRONZE AXEHEAD

Date 10th–7th century BCE

Origin Persia

Length 20.5cm (8in)

The blade on this spike-butt ax is set at an angle, which would have been impractical in combat, suggesting that the axe was for ceremonial use.



Double-edged blade